The commandos' reputation was built on endurance as much as firepower. They could spend three to five days on a combing operation, sometimes longer as supplies ran out, surviving on dry rations such as *chikki*s and carrying up to 25 kg of weapons, ammunition and other equipment through dense forests, with mines and ambushes a constant threat. "They come, carry out a joint operation with our boys and leave as stealthily as they arrive, leaving all the credit to be claimed by the local state police officials," an IPS officer from a neighbouring central Indian state tells INDIA TODAY.

FROM COMBAT TO POLICING

Now, some of these elite commandos are being asked to apply their skills to problems that look very different from an encounter in a forest. According to C.V. Anand, the Telangana director general of police (DGP), about 575 of the approximately 1,250 Greyhounds personnel are being redeployed according to operational requirements. As of now, the largest allocation, around 225 personnel, is going to the Traffic Management and Road Safety wing. Another 80 are being assigned to Food Adulteration and Drug Control, while 79 are moving to Vigilance and Enforcement. Others are being sent to Civil Supplies, Anti-Corruption Bureau, Crime Investigation Department and Cyber Security Bureau.

The redistribution reflects a broader transformation in what the police are expected to confront. "While LWE and terrorism were major challenges in the 1980s-2000s, the police are now increasingly required to deal with drug trafficking, cybercrime, online betting, investment fraud, traffic management, road safety and food adulteration," says Anand. Around 25 Greyhounds personnel have also been moved to T-SPARK, the Telangana Police's technology and AI wing, which is tasked with using advanced technologies to improve accuracy in criminal investigations and accelerate decision-making.



"With combing operations coming down, Greyhounds staff should be accommodated in other wings. The purpose for which the force was raised is already achieved"

REVANTH REDDY, *Chief Minister, Telangana, at Police Officers' Retreat 2026*

STATUS AND PURPOSE

The decision has nevertheless drawn criticism, particularly over the deployment of commandos in traffic management. "Repurposing of Greyhounds is needed as the Maoist menace and influence have faded, but using them as traffic cops manning the junctions is belittling the force's expertise and sacrifices over the last few decades," says N.V. Subhash, chief spokesperson of the Bharatiya Janata Party in Telangana.

A senior IPS officer who previously served as an assault commander with the Greyhounds shares the concern, saying that routine assignments could demoralise personnel who have long been held in high esteem by both their colleagues and the public. Their status within the force is reflected in the benefits attached to the role. The commandos receive an additional 60 per cent over basic pay. Their families receive support in the form of residential quarters, education and healthcare. If a Greyhound is killed in the line of duty, the family receives benefits, including Rs 1-2 crore in compensation, a government job and a 300 square yard plot.

Anand, however, argues that the redistribution is not arbitrary. Personnel were assessed on

THE MAKING OF AN ELITE FORCE

1989 Andhra Pradesh raises the Greyhounds as an elite anti-Naxal force

1993: IPS officer K.S. Vyas, instrumental in its formation, is killed by the People's War Group in Hyderabad

1995–2000s: The state invests heavily in intelligence and Greyhounds training. By 2000, the Hyderabad base is also training police from other Maoist-affected states

2008: A Maoist ambush at Balimela reservoir on the Andhra-Odisha border kills 32 Greyhounds commandos and six other police personnel

2014: After the state's bifurcation, both Telangana and Andhra Pradesh continue to have their own Greyhounds force, the latter based in Visakhapatnam

2016: Greyhounds conduct a major operation near Ramaguda in Odisha, killing 30+ Maoists, including several senior-level cadres

2017: Maoist activity declines sharply in the two states after years of Greyhounds operations and welfare efforts, even as the insurgency remains stronger in neighbouring Chhattisgarh